

>> the structure of a workout

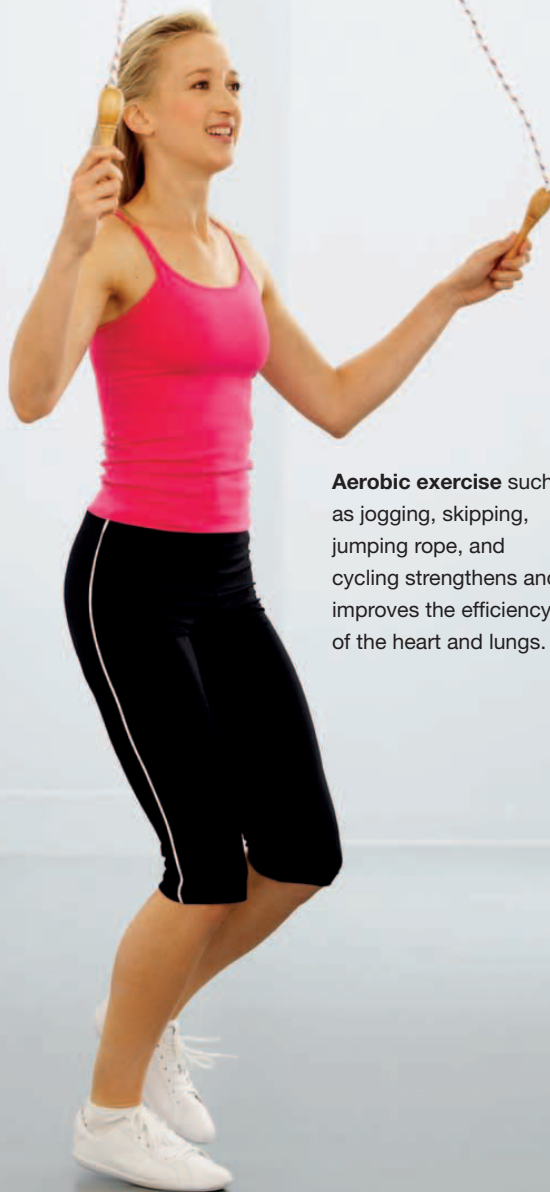
Usually, when you go to an aerobics class, you will notice that the exercise you do has three distinct sections. First there is the warm-up, second the aerobic section, and third, a toning and stretching section. These dance workouts are structured in exactly the same way.

The warm-up does exactly what you would imagine. It warms up the body and mobilizes the joints and muscles in preparation for the exercise that follows. If you walked into class without warming up and went straight into jumping, you could seriously injure yourself. By performing some light stretches as a warm-up, you open the joints, increase their range of motion, and get the body ready for more active movement.

The aerobic section

The aerobic section is the longest section of any aerobics class. It is designed to exercise your heart. The heart is a muscle and, just like other muscles, responds well to exercise. Your heart rate is the number of times your heart beats, or contracts, per minute. Doing aerobic exercise gently increases the number of beats per minute, raising the heart rate and strengthening the heart. The aerobic curve is a term used to describe how, during aerobic exercise, the heart rate is gently increased, sustained and then brought back down to your resting heart rate.

In this section, each dance workout consists of five basic movements (Level 1). These are then developed aerobically in various ways, such as by the addition of an arm movement, a deeper bend of the knees, or by traveling the movement through space (Level 2). At the peak of the aerobic curve, jumping movements are usually involved (Level 3). If you find these uncomfortable, then perhaps you are not yet ready for them. Don't



Aerobic exercise such as jogging, skipping, jumping rope, and cycling strengthens and improves the efficiency of the heart and lungs.